

A PRACTICAL GUIDE — FIRST EDITION



100

THINGS YOU CAN DO

WITH AI

*Everything you can actually use it for —
explained in plain English.*

100 USES · 100 PROMPTS

NO JARGON

100

Things You Can Do With AI

*A practical, plain-English guide for people who have
never really used it*

FIRST EDITION

First edition, 2026.

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Start Here

Five minutes that will make the rest of this book work

You are not behind

If you have opened an AI chatbot, typed something, received an underwhelming answer, and quietly closed the tab, you are in the majority. Most people's first encounter with AI is disappointing, and almost always for the same reason: they treated it like a search engine.

It isn't one. A search engine takes a few keywords and returns links. An AI assistant takes context, instructions, and a conversation, and produces work. The difference between a useless answer and a genuinely good one is rarely the tool. It is what you gave it to work with.

This book contains 100 specific things you can do, each with a prompt you can copy. You do not need any technical knowledge. You do not need to pay for anything to try most of them. And you do not need to read this in order - skip to whatever chapter matches a problem you actually have this week.

What these tools actually are

A modern AI assistant is a system trained on an enormous quantity of text, images, and code. From that training it has learned patterns of language, reasoning, and structure well enough to write, summarise, explain, translate, analyse, and generate. Increasingly it can also see images, hear speech, browse the web, run code, and work through multi-step tasks on your behalf.

Two consequences follow from how they work, and they matter more than any technical detail.

First, they can be confidently wrong. An AI can produce a fluent, well-structured, entirely fabricated answer - an invented statistic, a plausible book that does not exist, a legal rule from the wrong country. This is called hallucination, and it has not been solved. Anything that matters gets verified.

Second, they are not databases. They do not look things up unless they are connected to search. Recent events, current prices, and today's news are exactly what they are worst at, unless you use a search-connected tool.

The four tools to know

You do not need many. Almost everything in this book can be done with one of these, and each has a free tier that is genuinely usable.

ChatGPT (OpenAI) is the most widely used and the easiest starting point. Strong at almost everything, with good image generation, voice conversation, and file handling built in.

Claude (Anthropic) is particularly strong at writing, long documents, careful reasoning, and following detailed instructions. Many people find its writing the most natural.

Gemini (Google) is deeply integrated with Gmail, Docs, and the rest of Google's tools, handles very long documents well, and is free with a Google account.

Perplexity is search-first: it answers from the live web and shows you its sources. Use it whenever the answer depends on current facts.

There is no need to agonise over the choice. Pick one, use it for a fortnight, and try another. They are more alike than different, and the version numbers change every few months anyway.

The single habit that changes everything

Give it context, then tell it what you want, then say what good looks like.

Compare "write a marketing email" with: "I run a small bakery. Write an email to our 400 subscribers announcing that we now open on Sundays. Warm and plain, under 120 words, no exclamation marks, ending with our address and opening hours."

The first produces filler. The second produces something you could send after a light edit. That is the entire skill, and it takes about ten seconds longer.

The second habit worth building is to keep going. Almost nobody's first answer is their best one. Tell it what's wrong - too long, too formal, you missed the point, try a completely different angle - and ask again. Treat it as a conversation rather than a vending machine.

How to read this book

There are nine chapters, grouped by what you are trying to do rather than by which tool you are using. Every entry has the same shape: what it is, why it is worth your time, how to do it, a prompt you can copy and adapt, and the tools that do it best.

The prompts are starting points. Change the details to match your situation - that is the whole point of them. A prompt with your specifics in it will always beat a generic one.

One suggestion. Do not read all hundred and do none. Pick three from the first chapter, do them today, and come back. Everything in this book takes less time to do than to read about.

CHAPTER 1

01

Everyday Life and Home

The fastest way to get comfortable with AI is to point it at something you already do every week. Nothing in this chapter requires a subscription, a technical background, or more than five minutes. Start here, and the rest of the book will feel easy.

- 1 Plan a week of meals around what's already in your fridge
- 2 Get a workout plan built around your real life
- 3 Plan a trip with a realistic day-by-day itinerary
- 4 Identify a plant, a bug, or a mystery object from a photo
- 5 Fix things around the house with a photo and a conversation
- 6 Declutter and organise a room, one decision at a time
- 7 Get a straight answer instead of ten browser tabs
- 8 Turn a rambling voice note into a clean to-do list
- 9 Read a label, a menu, or a sign in another language
- 10 Settle a decision by having AI argue both sides
- 11 Explain a bill, a contract, or an official letter in plain English
- 12 Build a routine or habit plan you might actually keep

001

Plan a week of meals around what's already in your fridge

Turn leftover ingredients into an actual dinner plan.

Most food waste happens because nobody can think of what to cook at 7pm. An AI assistant is very good at this exact problem. Open ChatGPT, Claude, or Gemini, list what you have, and add your constraints: how many people, how much time, what you don't eat. In seconds you get a week of meals that use up what you already bought. Push back if you don't like something - say "the Thursday one is too much work, give me a 15-minute version" - and it will adjust. You can also snap a photo of your open fridge and ask it to read the shelves for you. Ask for a shopping list at the end and it will only list what's missing.

TRY THIS PROMPT

I have chicken thighs, half a cabbage, eggs, rice, yoghurt, and a jar of peanut butter. Plan 5 weeknight dinners for 2 people, max 30 minutes each, using as much of this as possible. Then give me a short shopping list of only what I still need.

TOOLS ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini

002

Get a workout plan built around your real life

A training plan that fits your equipment, schedule, and injuries.

Generic workout plans fail because they assume a full gym and unlimited time. AI is useful here because it will build around your actual constraints. Tell it your goal, how many days you can train, what equipment you own, your rough fitness level, and any injuries or limitations. Ask for a four-week plan with sets, reps, and rest. Then ask it to explain each movement in plain language so you know what you're doing. Come back weekly and tell it how it went - "week two felt too easy, the squats hurt my knee" - and ask it to adjust. Treat this as a

knowledgeable friend rather than a physiotherapist: if something hurts, see a real professional.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Build me a 4-week beginner strength plan. I can train 3 days a week for 40 minutes, I have two dumbbells and a mat, I'm 38 and haven't exercised in two years, and I have a sensitive lower back. Give me sets, reps, rest times, and a one-line description of how to do each exercise.

TOOLS ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini

003**Plan a trip with a realistic day-by-day itinerary**

A travel plan that accounts for distance, opening hours, and your energy.

Travel planning is tedious because it's a logistics puzzle. Give AI your dates, budget, city, and travel style, and ask for a day-by-day itinerary that groups activities by neighbourhood so you're not crossing town four times a day. Ask it to include rough costs, travel time between stops, and a rainy-day alternative for each day. Perplexity is particularly good for this because it searches the live web and shows sources, so you can check opening hours and current prices rather than trusting a model's memory. Always verify anything time-sensitive - opening days, ticket prices, visa rules - on the official website before you book.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Plan a 5-day trip to Lisbon in October for two people on a mid-range budget. We like food, walking, and history; we hate queues and early mornings. Group each day by neighbourhood, include travel time between stops, rough costs, and one indoor backup per day.

TOOLS Perplexity, ChatGPT, Gemini

004

Identify a plant, a bug, or a mystery object from a photo

Point your camera at something and find out what it is.

Every major AI assistant now accepts images. Take a photo of a plant, an insect, a rash on a leaf, a mushroom, a strange appliance part, or a symbol on a clothing label, and ask what it is. This is genuinely one of the most useful everyday features and it costs nothing. Follow-up questions are where it gets good: "is it safe for cats?", "how often should I water it?", "is this a spare part I can buy?". Two cautions worth taking seriously: never eat a mushroom or wild plant on an AI's say-so, and don't rely on it for medical diagnosis. For anything with real consequences, treat the answer as a starting point for a search, not a verdict.

TRY THIS PROMPT

What plant is this? Tell me how much light and water it needs, whether it's toxic to pets, and the three most common reasons its leaves might go yellow.

TOOLS ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude

005

Fix things around the house with a photo and a conversation

Diagnose a leak, a noise, or a broken fitting before calling anyone.

Before you pay for a callout, describe the problem to an AI and show it a photo. It can often narrow down what's wrong, tell you what the part is called, estimate whether this is a ten-minute fix or a real job, and warn you when something is genuinely a job for a licensed professional. Knowing the correct name for a part is half the battle when you're searching for a replacement. Ask it what tools you'd need and what could go wrong. The hard rule: anything involving gas, mains

electricity, or structural work gets a qualified tradesperson, no matter how confident the answer sounds.

TRY THIS PROMPT

My kitchen tap drips from the base of the spout, not the nozzle, and it got worse this month. Here's a photo. What's most likely wrong, what's the part called, is this a DIY job, and what tools would I need?

TOOLS ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude

006**Declutter and organise a room, one decision at a time**

A structured plan for a space that overwhelms you.

Clutter is paralysing because everything feels like it has to be decided at once. Photograph the room, upload it, and ask for a step-by-step plan broken into 20-minute sessions. AI is good at giving you a decision rule - what to keep, what to bin, what to donate - and at suggesting storage that fits the space you actually have. Ask it to start with the easiest win so you get momentum. You can also use it for the boring middle part: "write me a listing for this desk for a marketplace," or "what's a fair second-hand price for this?" The value here isn't clever advice, it's having something break a big task into small ones.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Here's a photo of my spare room, which has become a dumping ground. Give me a plan to clear it in five 20-minute sessions. Tell me exactly what to do in each session, starting with the fastest visible win, and give me a simple rule for deciding what to keep.

TOOLS ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude

007

Get a straight answer instead of ten browser tabs

Research a question and get a sourced summary in one place.

The old way to answer "which of these three should I buy" was opening fifteen tabs of affiliate blog posts. AI search tools do the reading for you. Perplexity, Gemini, and ChatGPT's search mode all pull live web results and cite their sources, so you get a comparison plus links to check. Ask for a table with the criteria you care about. Ask what the common complaints are in reviews. Ask what the cheapest option is that still does what you need. The habit that matters: always click at least one source. AI summaries are usually right and occasionally confidently wrong, and clicking through takes ten seconds.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Compare the three most recommended mid-range robot vacuums available right now for a home with a dog and mostly hard floors. Give me a table with price, suction, bin size, app quality, and the most common complaint from real reviews. Cite your sources.

TOOLS Perplexity, Gemini, ChatGPT

008

Turn a rambling voice note into a clean to-do list

Talk out loud and get back an organised list.

Speaking is roughly three times faster than typing, and most people think better out loud. Use your phone's voice input in the ChatGPT, Claude, or Gemini app and just talk - dump everything on your mind for two minutes, however messy. Then ask it to sort what you said into a prioritised task list, flag anything with a deadline, and note what you can delegate or drop. This works especially well for the Sunday-night brain-dump, or for the walk back from a meeting. It also turns out to be a decent way to think: the act of explaining your week to something that will organise it forces clarity.

TRY THIS PROMPT

I'm going to talk for two minutes about everything on my plate. Afterwards, sort it into: Do today, Do this week, Waiting on someone else, and Probably drop. Flag anything with a hard deadline and tell me what I seem to be avoiding.

TOOLS ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini

009**Read a label, a menu, or a sign in another language**

Instant translation from your camera, including context.

Point your phone at a restaurant menu, a medicine box, a road sign, or a form in a language you don't read, and ask what it says. Google Lens and the Gemini and ChatGPT apps all do this from a photo. The advantage over old translation apps is that you can ask follow-up questions: "which of these dishes has no dairy?", "is this the dosage for adults or children?", "what's this form actually asking me for?". You can also ask for the pronunciation so you can order out loud. DeepL remains the best pure text translator for longer documents, especially between European languages, and it's free for reasonable volumes.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Translate this menu photo into English. Then tell me which dishes are vegetarian, which are likely to be spicy, and how to pronounce the two you'd recommend for someone trying the cuisine for the first time.

TOOLS Google Lens, Gemini, ChatGPT, DeepL

010**Settle a decision by having AI argue both sides**

A structured pros-and-cons that isn't just telling you what you want.

AI assistants have a tendency to agree with you, which makes them useless for decisions unless you deliberately design against it. The fix is to ask for the argument you don't want. Describe the decision, then ask it to make the strongest possible case for each option in turn, list what would have to be true for each to be the right call, and name the biggest risk you're underweighting. Finish by asking what information would change the answer. Used this way it stops being a yes-machine and becomes something closer to a sparring partner. It's especially good for decisions where you already know your gut answer and want it stress-tested.

TRY THIS PROMPT

I'm deciding whether to move cities for a job. Make the strongest possible case for going, then the strongest possible case for staying. For each, list what would have to be true for it to be right. Then tell me the risk I'm most likely underestimating and what information would change your answer.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

011

Explain a bill, a contract, or an official letter in plain English

Understand the document you were too intimidated to read.

Insurance policies, tenancy agreements, terms of service, and government letters are written to be precise, not clear. Paste the text in or upload the PDF and ask for a plain-English summary, then ask the specific question you actually have. The most valuable prompt is asking what's unusual: "which clauses here are not standard?", "what am I agreeing to that I might not expect?", "what's the worst case for me under this contract?". Two things to remember. First, this is not legal advice, and for anything high-stakes you want a real professional. Second, be careful about uploading documents containing other people's personal data.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Here's my rental agreement. Summarise it in plain English in under 200 words. Then list any clauses that are unusual or that work against me, explain each in one sentence, and give me three specific questions I should ask the landlord before signing.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

012**Build a routine or habit plan you might actually keep**

A realistic schedule designed around your obstacles, not an ideal day.

The reason most routines fail is that they're designed for a version of you who has no children, no commute, and infinite willpower. Describe your real day - wake time, commitments, energy dips, what you've already tried and abandoned - and ask for a routine built around those constraints. The useful part is asking it to plan for failure: "what's the minimum version of this on a bad day?" and "what's most likely to derail this in week two?". Then check in weekly and report honestly what happened. Over a month this becomes a surprisingly effective accountability loop, mostly because writing down what actually happened is itself the habit.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Help me build an evening routine. I get home at 7, have a 4-year-old who sleeps at 8:30, and I want to read more and be off my phone by 11. I've tried and failed at this twice. Give me a realistic routine, a minimum version for bad days, and tell me what's most likely to break it in week two.

TOOLS ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini

CHAPTER 2

02

Writing and Communication

Writing is what AI does best, and it's where most people get the most value fastest. The trick is not asking it to write for you from nothing - that produces bland text. The trick is giving it your raw material, your context, and your voice, and using it to shape, sharpen, and finish.

13 Write the email you've been avoiding for three days

14 Fix your grammar and tighten your writing

15 Adapt one message for five different audiences

16 Summarise anything long into something you'll actually read

17 Beat writer's block with a proper outline

18 Get honest feedback on something you wrote

19 Teach AI your writing voice so drafts sound like you

20 Prepare for a difficult conversation by rehearsing it

21 Write a speech or toast that doesn't sound like a template

22 Turn one long piece into a dozen short ones

23 Write a cover letter that's actually about this job

24 Reply to reviews, complaints, and awkward comments

013

Write the email you've been avoiding for three days

Get past the blank page on a difficult message.

The emails we put off are almost always emotionally awkward: chasing a payment, declining an invitation, correcting a colleague, apologising. Describe the situation in plain terms - who it's to, what happened, what outcome you want, how blunt you're willing to be - and ask for a draft. Then edit. The AI draft is rarely the version you send; it's the thing that gets you unstuck. Ask for three versions at different levels of directness and you'll usually find the right register somewhere between them. Always rewrite at least a few sentences in your own words so it sounds like you and not like a template.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Write an email to a client who is 6 weeks late paying a 2,000 invoice. We want to keep the relationship. Give me three versions: warm, neutral, and firm-but-professional. Keep each under 120 words and don't use corporate filler.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

014

Fix your grammar and tighten your writing

Catch mistakes and cut the words you don't need.

Paste any piece of writing and ask for a corrected version plus a short list of what you changed and why. The second part matters: over a few months you'll stop making the same mistakes. Ask specifically for cuts - "make this 30 percent shorter without losing meaning" is one of the highest-value prompts in this book, because almost all first drafts are too long. Grammarly does this continuously as you type across your browser and apps; a chat assistant does it better for whole pieces and

can explain its reasoning. Non-native English speakers get an enormous amount out of this, and so do native speakers who write long.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Correct the grammar in this text, then give me a version that's 30% shorter without losing any meaning. Below the rewrite, list the five most useful changes you made and explain each in one line so I can learn from it.

TOOLS Grammarly, Claude, ChatGPT

015

Adapt one message for five different audiences

Say the same thing to your boss, your team, and your customers.

Most announcements need to exist in several versions. Write the message once, then ask AI to adapt it: a two-line Slack message for the team, a formal paragraph for the client, a LinkedIn post, a plain-language version for someone outside your industry. This is where AI genuinely saves an hour rather than five minutes, because the rewriting is mechanical but tedious. Be explicit about what changes between versions - length, formality, how much jargon, what to lead with. A useful extra step: ask what each audience is most likely to be worried about, and whether the draft addresses it.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Here's an announcement about a two-week delay to our product launch. Rewrite it as: (1) a 3-line Slack message to the internal team, (2) a formal email to enterprise customers, (3) a short LinkedIn post. For each audience, tell me what they'll be most worried about and make sure the version addresses it.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

016

Summarise anything long into something you'll actually read

Reports, threads, transcripts, and PDFs, compressed.

Upload a document, paste a transcript, or drop in a long email thread and ask for a summary. Generic summaries are mediocre; specific ones are excellent. Instead of "summarise this," ask "what are the three decisions made in this meeting and who owns each?" or "what does this report say that contradicts what we assumed?" or "what would someone who disagrees with this document say?". Ask for the summary in a fixed shape - bullets, a table, five sentences - and it becomes scannable. For long documents, ask for a summary per section first, then a summary of those, which produces better results than one giant pass.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Here's a 40-page report. Give me: (1) the core argument in 3 sentences, (2) the 5 most important findings as bullets with the numbers attached, (3) anything the report claims that isn't well supported by its own evidence, and (4) three questions I should ask the author.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, NotebookLM, Gemini

017

Beat writer's block with a proper outline

Structure first, so the writing itself becomes easy.

Blank-page paralysis is usually a structure problem, not a writing problem. Tell AI what you're writing, who it's for, and what you want the reader to do or feel at the end, then ask for three different outlines using different structural approaches. Pick one, argue with it, and only then start writing. Doing it this way keeps your voice intact - the AI shaped the skeleton, you wrote the words. You can also hand it your messy notes and ask what the natural structure hiding inside them is,

which is often better than any outline you'd have invented from scratch.

TRY THIS PROMPT

I want to write a 1,200-word article for small business owners about why their website isn't converting. Give me three different outlines using three different structures (problem-solution, listicle, and narrative case study). For each, note who it works best for and what its weakness is.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

018

Get honest feedback on something you wrote

A critique, not a compliment.

AI will praise your writing by default, which is worthless. You have to explicitly ask for the opposite. Tell it to act as a demanding editor, to skip all praise, and to give you the three weakest parts with specific fixes. Ask where a reader is most likely to stop reading. Ask what a sceptical member of your audience would push back on. Ask whether the opening earns the second paragraph. The feedback you get this way is genuinely useful and, unlike a human editor, available at midnight before a deadline. Do it before you send anything that matters.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Act as a tough editor. Skip all compliments. Here's my draft. Tell me: the three weakest sentences and how to fix each, the exact point where a reader would stop reading and why, and the strongest objection a sceptical reader would raise that I haven't addressed.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

019

Teach AI your writing voice so drafts sound like you

Stop everything reading like a press release.

The reason AI writing sounds generic is that you haven't shown it anything specific. Paste in three or four things you've written - emails, posts, anything - and ask it to describe your voice: sentence length, vocabulary, how formal, what you never do. Then save that description and paste it at the top of future requests. The improvement is dramatic. Ban lists help too: tell it never to use "delve," "leverage," "in today's fast-paced world," em-dashes, or three-item lists if those aren't your habits. ChatGPT's custom instructions and Claude's project instructions let you store this once instead of repeating it.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Here are four things I've written. Analyse my writing voice in detail: typical sentence length, vocabulary level, formality, rhetorical habits, and words or structures I never use. Write it as a reusable style brief I can paste at the start of future prompts.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

020

Prepare for a difficult conversation by rehearsing it

Role-play the conversation before you have it.

Asking for a raise, ending a contract, giving hard feedback, or telling a family member something they don't want to hear - these go better with practice. Describe the other person, their likely position, and their personality, then ask the AI to play them realistically and push back the way they would. Have the conversation. Then step out of role and ask for feedback on how you handled it and what you should have said differently. This is one of the most underrated uses in this book. It costs nothing, nobody sees you fumble the first attempt, and you can run it five times.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Role-play as my manager, who is supportive but budget-conscious and dislikes surprises. I'm going to ask for a 15% raise. Push back realistically and don't make it easy. After 10 exchanges, break character and tell me what I did well, what I fumbled, and the strongest line I didn't use.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

021

Write a speech or toast that doesn't sound like a template

A wedding toast, eulogy, or presentation that sounds like a person.

The trick with speeches is that AI can't invent your memories, so don't ask it to. Instead, tell it four or five specific true things - a story, a habit, a phrase the person always says - and ask it to build a structure around them. Give it the length in minutes rather than words, since speaking pace matters, and roughly 130 words per minute is a good estimate. Ask for a strong opening line and a closing that lands. Then read it aloud and cut everything that feels unnatural in your mouth. The AI provides the shape; the specifics have to come from you or the whole thing falls flat.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Help me write a 3-minute best man's speech. True details: we met queuing for a bus in 2009, he once drove 6 hours to help me move a sofa, he can't cook anything except one very good curry, and he met his wife at a table tennis club. Warm and funny, not cheesy. Give me a strong opening line and a closing that lands.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

022

Turn one long piece into a dozen short ones

Repurpose an article into posts, emails, and scripts.

If you've written something good, you've already done the hard part. Feed it back in and ask for the derivatives: a LinkedIn post, five tweets, an email newsletter version, a short video script, three quote graphics' worth of pull quotes, and a set of discussion questions. Be specific about the platform, because what works on LinkedIn dies on Instagram. This is how one piece of real thinking becomes a month of content. The quality holds up because the substance is yours - AI is only reformatting. Ask it to pull the single most surprising sentence in the original and build the shortest version around that.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Here's a 1,500-word article I wrote. Turn it into: a LinkedIn post under 200 words that opens with the most surprising claim, 5 standalone tweets, a 150-word newsletter intro, and a 45-second video script. Keep my voice - don't add hype or emojis.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

023

Write a cover letter that's actually about this job

Match your experience to a specific job description.

Generic cover letters get ignored because they clearly weren't written for the role. Paste the job description and your CV, and ask AI to identify the three requirements the employer cares about most and where your experience maps to each - including the gaps. Then ask for a draft that leads with the strongest match. The output is a starting point: rewrite it so it sounds like you, and cut anything that overstates your experience. Never let it invent achievements. A useful follow-up is asking what a hiring manager would be sceptical about in your application, which tells you what to address directly.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Here's a job description and my CV. First, list the 3 things this employer most cares about and rate how well I match each, honestly, including gaps. Then write a 250-word cover letter leading with my strongest match. Invent nothing. Finally, tell me what a hiring manager would be sceptical about.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

024

Reply to reviews, complaints, and awkward comments

Professional responses when you're annoyed.

The worst time to write a reply to a bad review is immediately after reading it. Paste the complaint in, describe what actually happened from your side, and ask for a response that acknowledges the specific issue, avoids defensiveness, and offers a concrete next step. Ask for it to be short - long replies read as defensive. This works for one-star reviews, angry customer emails, and public comments. A good habit is asking it to flag anything in your side of the story that would look bad if quoted publicly, because that's the part you'll regret. Then send it after a cup of tea, not before.

TRY THIS PROMPT

A customer left a 1-star review saying their order arrived 5 days late and nobody replied to their email. That's accurate - we had a warehouse issue. Write a public reply under 80 words that takes responsibility, doesn't grovel, and offers a specific fix. Flag anything in my explanation I shouldn't say publicly.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

CHAPTER 3

03

Learning and Studying

AI is at its most transformative as a tutor. It has infinite patience, it will explain the same thing eight different ways, and it never makes you feel stupid for asking. The one rule: use it to understand things, not to skip understanding them.

25 Have anything explained at exactly your level

26 Turn your notes into flashcards automatically

27 Build a study guide from your own documents

28 Practise a language by having real conversations

29 Get unstuck on a maths or science problem without the answer

30 Build a learning plan for a skill from scratch

31 Read academic research without a PhD

32 Turn a document into a podcast you can listen to

33 Test yourself with an exam you didn't write

34 Understand a chart, diagram, or table you can't read

35 Learn from a YouTube video without watching all of it

36 Give your children a patient homework tutor

025

Have anything explained at exactly your level

The same concept, pitched to what you already know.

The single best learning prompt is to state your current level and ask for an explanation pitched there. "Explain how a mortgage works to someone who has never had a bank loan." "Explain compound interest to a 12-year-old." "Explain transformers to someone who understands basic statistics but not neural networks." If the answer is still too complex, say so and ask again simpler; if it's patronising, ask for the next level up. This back-and-forth is the whole point and it's something a textbook cannot do. Finish by asking it to check your understanding: explain the idea back in your own words and ask what you got wrong.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Explain how inflation works to someone who has no economics background at all. Use one everyday analogy. Then give me the slightly more advanced version. Then ask me two questions to check whether I actually understood it.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

026

Turn your notes into flashcards automatically

Study material generated from your own course content.

Paste your lecture notes, a chapter, or a PDF and ask for flashcards in question-and-answer format. Ask for them as a two-column list you can paste straight into Anki or Quizlet, which both import from CSV. The important instruction is to make the questions test understanding rather than recall of exact phrasing - ask for "why" and "what would happen if" cards alongside definitions. RemNote and Quizlet have this built in. Doing it from your own notes rather than a generic deck

matters, because you'll be tested on your course, not on someone else's. Ask it to flag the five concepts most likely to appear in an exam.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Here are my lecture notes on cell respiration. Create 25 flashcards as a two-column CSV I can import into Anki. Mix definitions with 'why' and 'what happens if' questions. At the end, list the 5 concepts most likely to come up in an exam and why.

TOOLS ChatGPT, Claude, Quizlet, RemNote

027**Build a study guide from your own documents**

Turn readings and slides into a single revision resource.

Google's NotebookLM is built specifically for this: you upload your sources - PDFs, slides, notes, links - and it answers only from those documents, with citations pointing to the exact passage. That constraint is the feature, because it dramatically reduces the risk of made-up answers. Upload a semester of material and ask for a study guide, a timeline, a briefing document, or a set of FAQs. It will also generate an audio overview - two synthetic hosts discussing your material - which is genuinely useful for revising on a commute. For students, this is probably the highest-value free AI tool available right now.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Using only the documents I've uploaded, create a study guide for this module: key concepts with definitions, a timeline of the main events, the 10 questions most likely to appear in an exam with model answers, and a glossary. Cite the source for each point.

TOOLS NotebookLM

028

Practise a language by having real conversations

A conversation partner who never gets bored or judges you.

The bottleneck in language learning is speaking practice, and it's expensive and intimidating to get. Use the voice mode in ChatGPT or Gemini and ask it to converse with you in your target language at a specific level, correcting your mistakes as you go. Set the scenario - ordering food, a job interview, complaining to a landlord - and set the rules: correct me immediately, or only at the end, or only for mistakes that would confuse a native speaker. Ask it to speak slower or faster. The lack of embarrassment is the real advantage; most learners will say things to an AI that they'd be too self-conscious to attempt with a person.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Let's have a conversation in Spanish at an upper-beginner level. You're a shopkeeper, I'm buying ingredients for dinner. Speak slowly. After each of my replies, briefly correct any mistake that a native speaker would notice, then continue naturally in character.

TOOLS ChatGPT, Gemini, Duolingo

029

Get unstuck on a maths or science problem without the answer

A tutor that gives hints instead of solutions.

The wrong way to use AI on homework is to ask for the answer. The right way is to ask for one hint at a time. Tell it explicitly: don't solve it, tell me what the next step should be and why. When you get it wrong, ask where your reasoning broke down. This is Socratic tutoring and it's how you actually learn. Photograph a handwritten problem and it will read it. Be aware that AI models still make arithmetic mistakes, so ask it to check its work or verify numerically. Wolfram Alpha remains

more reliable for pure computation; use AI for the explanation and Wolfram for the arithmetic.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Here's a physics problem I'm stuck on. Do NOT give me the answer. Tell me only what the next step is and why that step is the right one. Then wait for my attempt. If I get it wrong, tell me exactly where my reasoning broke down.

TOOLS ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Wolfram Alpha

030**Build a learning plan for a skill from scratch**

A curriculum for something you want to learn in your own time.

Tell it what you want to learn, how much time you have per week, your starting point, and what you want to be able to do at the end. Ask for a week-by-week plan with specific milestones and a small project at each stage, because projects are what make skills stick. Ask it to name the standard free resources for each topic - but then verify those links actually exist, because AI will occasionally invent plausible-sounding book titles and URLs. Come back weekly, report what you did, and ask it to adjust. Having something track your progress is a surprisingly large part of why this works.

TRY THIS PROMPT

I want to learn data analysis with Python. I have 5 hours a week and 6 months, and I can use spreadsheets but have never coded. Build me a month-by-month plan with a concrete project at the end of each month and specific free resources. Tell me how I'll know I'm ready to move on from each stage.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

031

Read academic research without a PhD

Find, filter, and understand scientific papers.

Tools like Elicit, Consensus, and Semantic Scholar search across millions of papers and summarise what the research actually says about a question, with links to the studies. Consensus is good for the blunt question - "does intermittent fasting work?" - and shows you how many papers agree. Then take a specific paper, upload the PDF to Claude or ChatGPT, and ask for a plain-English explanation of the method, the finding, and the limitations. The limitations question is the important one; abstracts oversell and AI summaries inherit that. Always check the sample size, whether it was in humans, and whether anyone has replicated it.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Here's a research paper PDF. Explain in plain English: what question they asked, what they actually did, what they found, and how confident we should be. Then list the three biggest limitations and tell me what a sceptical scientist would say about this study.

TOOLS Elicit, Consensus, Claude, ChatGPT

032

Turn a document into a podcast you can listen to

Convert reading into listening for your commute.

NotebookLM's audio overview takes documents you upload and generates a conversation between two synthetic hosts discussing the material - roughly ten minutes, and surprisingly listenable. It works for study notes, work reports, a contract, or a stack of articles you've been meaning to read. Separately, apps like Speechify and ElevenLabs Reader will read any PDF, article, or email aloud in a natural voice, at speeds up to three or four times normal. For people who don't retain much from reading, or who have dyslexia, or who simply have a commute, this

converts dead time into learning time. Both have free tiers worth trying.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Generate an audio overview of the documents I've uploaded, focused on the practical implications rather than the theory, and aimed at someone who needs to make a decision based on this material.

TOOLS NotebookLM, Speechify, ElevenLabs Reader

033**Test yourself with an exam you didn't write**

Practice questions generated from your material.

Retrieval practice - being tested - is one of the few study techniques with strong evidence behind it, and it beats re-reading by a wide margin. Upload your material and ask for a practice exam that matches the real format: number of questions, question types, marks per question, time limit. Answer it properly under timed conditions, then paste your answers back and ask for marking against a rubric, with specific feedback on what a top answer would have included. Ask for a follow-up quiz focused only on what you got wrong. This loop, repeated three or four times, is worth more than a week of highlighting.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Based on my uploaded notes, write a practice exam: 4 short-answer questions (5 marks each) and 1 essay question (20 marks), 90-minute limit. Don't show answers yet. After I submit, mark my answers against a rubric, give a score per question, and tell me exactly what a full-marks answer would have included.

TOOLS ChatGPT, Claude, NotebookLM

034

Understand a chart, diagram, or table you can't read

Upload a confusing visual and have it explained.

Financial charts, medical scans, engineering diagrams, statistical plots, wiring schematics, nutrition labels - photograph any of them and ask what you're looking at. Then ask the follow-ups that a textbook can't answer: what should I be noticing here, is this normal, what would concern an expert, what's the axis actually measuring. This is one of the clearest demonstrations of how AI differs from search, because you cannot search for something when you don't know what it's called. For anything medical, use it to understand terminology and prepare questions for your doctor, not to reach conclusions.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Here's a chart from a company's annual report. Explain what it's showing in plain English, tell me what an experienced analyst would notice immediately, and flag anything about how it's presented that might be misleading.

TOOLS ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude

035

Learn from a YouTube video without watching all of it

Summarise, search, and extract from video content.

Paste a YouTube link into Gemini or a summariser and ask for the key points with timestamps, so you can jump to the part you need. For a two-hour tutorial, ask for the steps as a numbered list; for a lecture, ask for the argument and the evidence. If you need to go deeper, tools like Descript or free transcript extractors give you the full text, which you can then paste into any assistant for detailed questions. This turns video, which is slow and unsearchable, into text, which is fast and searchable - a genuine unlock for anyone learning from online courses.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Summarise this YouTube video. Give me the main argument in 3 sentences, then a numbered list of the key points with timestamps so I can jump to any of them, then the three most useful practical takeaways.

TOOLS Gemini, NotebookLM, Descript

036**Give your children a patient homework tutor**

Age-appropriate help that explains rather than answers.

Set the ground rules explicitly and this works well: tell the AI the child's age, the subject, and that it must never give the answer - only hints, questions, and encouragement. Khan Academy's Khanmigo is purpose-built for this and is designed not to hand over solutions. For general assistants, sit with your child the first few times so you can see how they use it. Two things worth being honest about with older children: AI gets things wrong, and using it to produce homework they didn't do is both detectable and pointless. Frame it as a tutor who's always available, not a machine that does the work.

TRY THIS PROMPT

You're tutoring my 10-year-old on fractions. Never give the answer - ask guiding questions and give hints one at a time. Use simple language and everyday examples. Be encouraging when she gets it wrong. Start by asking her what she already understands about fractions.

TOOLS Khanmigo, ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini

04

Work and Productivity

This is where AI pays for itself. Most office work contains a large amount of structured, repetitive thinking - summarising, formatting, drafting, extracting, checking - and that is precisely what these tools are good at. The aim isn't to work faster on everything; it's to stop spending your best hours on the parts that don't need you.

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49 Get a second opinion before you make a decision

50 Draft, review, and compare contracts

037

Never take meeting notes again

Automatic transcripts, summaries, and action items.

AI notetakers join your video calls, transcribe everything, and produce a summary with decisions and action items assigned to people. Otter.ai, Fireflies, and Granola are the common choices; Zoom, Teams, Google Meet, and Notion all have versions built in now. The output is usually good enough to send as minutes with light editing. Two practical notes. First, tell people they're being recorded - in many places it's a legal requirement, and everywhere it's basic courtesy. Second, ask for the format you want: "decisions, owners, deadlines, open questions" beats a generic summary every time. Search across past transcripts is the underrated feature; you can find what someone committed to two months ago in seconds.

TRY THIS PROMPT

From this meeting transcript, give me: decisions made, action items with owner and deadline, open questions nobody answered, and anything where two people appeared to disagree without resolving it. Keep it under 300 words.

TOOLS Otter.ai, Fireflies, Granola, Notion AI

038

Clear your inbox faster

Draft replies, summarise threads, and triage what matters.

Gmail's Gemini features and Outlook's Copilot will summarise a long thread, draft a reply in a chosen tone, and pull out anything that needs action. Even without those, you can paste a thread into any assistant and ask what's actually being asked of you - which on a forty-message chain is a real service. The workflow that saves the most time is batching: at the end of the day, paste your ten hardest emails in and

generate all the drafts at once, then edit and send. Be careful about pasting confidential or personal information into consumer AI tools; check your employer's policy first.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Here's a long email thread. Tell me in 5 bullets what's been decided, what's still open, and specifically what is being asked of me. Then draft a reply that answers only my part, is under 100 words, and doesn't reopen settled questions.

TOOLS Gemini in Gmail, Microsoft Copilot, Claude, ChatGPT

039

Build a spreadsheet formula by describing it

Say what you want in English, get the formula.

Nobody remembers INDEX/MATCH syntax. Describe what you want - "look up the value in column A in the other sheet and return the price, but show blank instead of an error" - and ask for the formula for Excel or Google Sheets, plus an explanation of each part. It also works in reverse: paste a monstrous inherited formula and ask what it does. Ask it to check your logic for edge cases like empty cells and duplicates, which is where most spreadsheets quietly go wrong. Both Excel's Copilot and Google Sheets' Gemini can now do this in the sidebar with your actual data in view.

TRY THIS PROMPT

In Google Sheets, I have order data in Sheet1 (columns: date, customer, product, amount). I want a formula in Sheet2 that sums the total amount per customer for last month only, ignoring blank rows. Give me the formula, explain each part, and tell me what could break it.

TOOLS Microsoft Copilot, Gemini in Sheets, ChatGPT, Claude

040

Analyse a spreadsheet without knowing how to analyse spreadsheets

Upload data and ask questions in plain English.

Upload a CSV or Excel file to ChatGPT or Claude and ask questions about it directly: what's the trend, which customers are growing, where are the outliers, what's the split by region. Both can run actual code on the data rather than guessing, which means the numbers are calculated rather than invented - though it's still worth spot-checking a couple against the source. Ask for a chart and you'll get an image you can download. The most valuable prompt is open-ended: "what's the most interesting thing in this data that I probably haven't noticed?" Strip out personal data before uploading anything that isn't yours.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Here's 18 months of sales data as a CSV. Tell me the overall trend, the three biggest changes between the first and second half, any obvious outliers or data quality problems, and the single most interesting pattern I probably haven't noticed. Then make me a clear chart of the main finding.

TOOLS ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini

041

Build a slide deck from a document

Turn a report or brief into presentable slides.

Gamma is the standout here: paste in text or a prompt and it generates a designed deck you can edit, with sensible layouts and images. Microsoft's Copilot does the same inside PowerPoint, and Google's Gemini inside Slides. The realistic expectation is that you get to eighty percent - the structure and layout are done, and you rewrite the words. Ask for a specific slide count and audience, because the default is always too many slides with too much text. A useful trick: ask for the story arc first as bullets, approve that, and only then generate slides. It prevents a beautifully designed deck that argues nothing.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Turn this project brief into a 10-slide deck for a senior leadership audience who have 15 minutes. One idea per slide, max 20 words of text per slide, and a clear recommendation on slide 3 rather than at the end. First show me the slide-by-slide outline before generating anything.

TOOLS Gamma, Microsoft Copilot, Gemini in Slides

042**Prepare for a meeting in five minutes**

Background, talking points, and likely objections.

Before any meeting that matters, give AI the context - who's attending, what's on the agenda, what outcome you want, what's happened before - and ask for a one-page brief. The genuinely useful parts are the ones you'd skip yourself: the three most likely objections and how to answer each, the questions you should ask, and what a good outcome looks like specifically. For external meetings, use Perplexity to research the company and the person first, then feed that in. Ten minutes of this reliably makes you the most prepared person in the room, which is a low bar and a large advantage.

TRY THIS PROMPT

I'm meeting a potential client tomorrow to pitch a 6-month consulting engagement. Here's what I know about them and what I want. Give me a one-page brief: three talking points, the four objections they're most likely to raise with a response to each, five questions I should ask them, and what a good outcome looks like.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Perplexity

043**Write the job description, then screen against it**

Hiring paperwork, faster and more consistent.

Describe the role, the team, and what success looks like in the first six months, and ask for a job description that avoids clichés and states the actual requirements rather than a wish list. Then ask for a scorecard - the specific criteria you'll assess candidates against - which makes interviews more consistent and fairer. You can also generate interview questions targeted at each criterion. Be careful here: do not use AI to automatically rank or reject real candidates, both because it can encode bias and because in a growing number of jurisdictions automated employment decisions are legally regulated. Use it for the preparation, keep humans on the judgement.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Write a job description for a marketing coordinator at a 12-person B2B software company. No clichés, no 'rockstar', no 20-item requirement lists. Separate must-haves from nice-to-haves honestly. Then give me a 5-criterion scorecard and two interview questions per criterion.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

044

Automate the repetitive task you do every week

Connect your apps so a routine job runs itself.

Zapier and Make connect apps together - when a form is submitted, add a row to a sheet, send a Slack message, and create a task - and both now let you describe the automation in plain English and have it built for you. Start with something small and genuinely repetitive: saving email attachments to a folder, logging form responses, posting new blog posts to social media. Many now include an AI step, so you can have the content summarised or categorised as it passes through. The rule of thumb: if you do it more than once a week and it involves moving information between two apps, it's probably automatable in under an hour.

TRY THIS PROMPT

I want to automate this: every time someone submits our contact form, save their details to a Google Sheet, send a Slack message to the sales channel with a one-line summary of their enquiry, and send them a confirmation email. Walk me through building this in Zapier step by step, assuming I've never used it.

TOOLS Zapier, Make, n8n

045**Get a project plan with realistic timelines**

Break a vague goal into tasks, order, and dependencies.

Describe the project, the deadline, who's available, and the constraints, and ask for a plan broken into phases with tasks, owners, dependencies, and estimates. The two prompts that add the most value are asking what's on the critical path, and asking for a pre-mortem: "assume this failed - what most likely went wrong?" That surfaces the risks nobody wants to raise in the kickoff meeting. Expect the time estimates to be optimistic, as all estimates are; ask for a best case and a realistic case. Then paste the plan into whatever tool you actually use rather than trying to manage the project inside a chat window.

TRY THIS PROMPT

We're launching a new website in 10 weeks with a team of 4 (designer, developer, marketer, me). Give me a phased plan with tasks, owners, dependencies, and realistic estimates. Flag the critical path. Then do a pre-mortem: assume we missed the deadline by a month and tell me the five most likely reasons.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Notion AI

046**Turn a messy pile of information into a clean table**

Extract structured data from unstructured text.

Paste in a page of business cards, a chain of emails, a supplier's PDF quote, or a wall of unformatted notes, and ask for it as a table with the columns you name. This is quietly one of the biggest time savers in office work, because the alternative is copy-pasting for an hour. Ask for it as CSV and paste straight into a spreadsheet. Specify what to do with missing values so you don't get invented ones - "leave blank if not stated" is an essential instruction. Then spot-check a few rows against the source, because extraction errors are easy to miss once the data looks tidy.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Here's a PDF of 30 supplier quotes in inconsistent formats. Extract them into a CSV with these columns: supplier, item, unit price, currency, minimum order, lead time, contact email. If a value isn't stated, leave it blank - do not guess or infer anything.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

047

Write standard operating procedures for your team

Document the process that currently lives in someone's head.

Every small team has processes that only one person knows, which becomes a problem the day that person is on holiday. Have that person describe the process out loud - a voice note is fine - then ask AI to turn it into a clear numbered procedure with prerequisites, steps, common mistakes, and what to do when something goes wrong. Ask it to flag the steps where the description was vague, which is exactly where the undocumented knowledge is hiding. Then have someone who has never done the task follow it and note where they get stuck. This turns a two-hour documentation job into twenty minutes.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Here's a transcript of our office manager explaining how she onboards a new employee. Turn it into a clear SOP: prerequisites, numbered steps, who's responsible for each, common mistakes, and what to do if something goes wrong. Flag any step where her explanation was vague or assumed knowledge.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Notion AI

048

Search across everything your company has written

Ask a question and get an answer from your own files.

Notion AI, Microsoft Copilot, and Glean can search across your organisation's documents, emails, and chats and answer questions with citations - "what did we agree with this client about the renewal terms?" rather than hunting through folders. For a smaller setup, NotebookLM does the same for a bounded set of documents you upload, for free. The value grows with the amount of material: the more your team has written down, the more this recovers. The caveat is permissions - make sure the tool respects who is allowed to see what, especially with HR and finance documents in the same workspace.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Search our workspace and tell me everything we've documented about the Henderson account: what we agreed, what the current status is, who has been involved, and any unresolved issues. Cite the source document for each point.

TOOLS Notion AI, Microsoft Copilot, Glean, NotebookLM

049

Get a second opinion before you make a decision

Stress-test your plan against a critic.

Describe a decision you've already made and ask AI to argue against it as hard as it can. Ask what a sceptical board member, a competitor, or your most difficult customer would say. Ask what you're assuming that might not be true. Ask what the second-order consequences are - what happens as a result of the thing that happens. Because AI defaults to agreement, you have to demand the critique explicitly and repeatedly; a good phrase is "give me the three strongest objections, and don't soften them." This is thirty seconds of work that occasionally saves a very expensive mistake.

TRY THIS PROMPT

We're planning to raise our prices by 20% across the board next quarter. Argue against this as hard as you can. Give me the three strongest objections without softening them, list the assumptions we're making that might be wrong, and describe the second-order effects we probably haven't considered.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

050

Draft, review, and compare contracts

First drafts and red flags on routine paperwork.

For routine documents - a freelance agreement, an NDA, a statement of work - AI can produce a reasonable first draft and, more usefully, review one you've been sent. Ask it to list every obligation you're taking on, every termination condition, and anything unusual compared to a standard agreement of this type. Ask what's missing that you'd normally expect to see, which is often more revealing than what's present. Then, for anything that matters, have a lawyer look at it. AI is excellent at making sure you understand what you're signing and arrive at the lawyer with good questions; it is not a substitute for one.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Review this freelance contract from the contractor's perspective. List every obligation I'd be taking on, all termination and payment terms, anything unusual for this type of agreement, and anything standard that's missing. Rank the top five things I should negotiate, most important first.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

CHAPTER 5

05

Money, Admin and Decisions

A warning before this chapter: AI is not a financial adviser, an accountant, or a lawyer, and it will state wrong numbers with complete confidence. What it is genuinely good at is helping you understand your own situation, organise the boring parts, and arrive at a professional with better questions.

- 51** Understand where your money actually goes
- 52** Build a budget that reflects your real life
- 53** Compare financial products without the sales pitch
- 54** Prepare for tax season without panic
- 55** Negotiate a bill or a price

- 56** Understand your insurance or medical paperwork
- 57** Plan a big purchase properly
- 58** Write the difficult admin letter
- 59** Track a goal and stay honest about progress
- 60** Get help with a decision you keep going in circles on

051**Understand where your money actually goes**

Analyse your own spending and find the patterns.

Export a few months of transactions from your bank as a CSV, remove your account number and any names, and upload it. Ask for a breakdown by category, the trend over time, subscriptions you may have forgotten, and the three changes that would save the most money with the least pain. Because these tools can run real calculations on the file rather than estimating, the numbers are reliable - though it's worth checking one category total against your bank. The insight that usually lands hardest is the annualised figure: a small weekly habit shown as a yearly number is unusually persuasive.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Here are 6 months of my bank transactions as a CSV. Categorise the spending, show me the monthly trend per category, list every recurring subscription you can identify with its annual cost, and tell me the three changes that would save the most money for the least lifestyle impact.

TOOLS ChatGPT, Claude

052**Build a budget that reflects your real life**

A spending plan based on what you actually spend.

Most budgets fail because they're aspirational fiction. Give AI your real income, fixed costs, and your actual average spending from the exercise above, and ask for a budget that's achievable rather than ideal. Ask it to build in a category for the irregular things that wreck budgets - car repairs, gifts, medical costs - which is the single most common reason people abandon one. Ask for two versions: a comfortable one and a strict one, so you can see the trade-off. Then ask what would

happen if your income dropped by twenty percent, which tells you where your real vulnerability is.

TRY THIS PROMPT

My take-home is 3,200 a month. Fixed costs are rent 1,100, utilities 180, transport 140, phone and internet 70. I want to save for a house deposit. Build me a realistic monthly budget including a sinking fund for irregular costs. Give me a comfortable version and a strict version, and tell me how long the deposit takes under each.

TOOLS ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini

053

Compare financial products without the sales pitch

Understand the actual differences between options.

Insurance policies, mortgages, credit cards, and savings accounts are deliberately hard to compare. Paste in the key terms of two or three options and ask for a comparison table on the dimensions you care about, plus what each provider is hoping you won't notice. Ask what the total cost is over the full term, not the headline rate, because that's where the differences live. Use Perplexity to check current rates, since a model's training data will be out of date. Then confirm every number on the provider's own website before you commit to anything - AI is a good filter, not a source of truth about your money.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Here are the terms of three home insurance policies. Compare them in a table: annual cost, excess, what's covered, what's excluded, and claim limits. Then tell me, for a flat with no history of flooding, which represents best value and what each insurer is hoping I won't read carefully.

TOOLS Perplexity, Claude, ChatGPT

054

Prepare for tax season without panic

Organise records and understand what you can claim.

Ask what documents you need for your situation, what categories of expense typically apply to your type of work, and what records you should be keeping through the year. Upload a spreadsheet of expenses and ask it to categorise them and flag anything that looks questionable. What you should not do is rely on it for the actual rules, which vary by country, change annually, and are exactly the sort of specific factual detail AI gets wrong. Use it to build your list of questions and to arrive at your accountant organised - that alone can reduce what you pay them.

TRY THIS PROMPT

I'm a freelance graphic designer working from home. Give me a checklist of the records and documents I should be keeping for tax purposes, and the categories of expense freelancers in my line of work typically need to track. Then give me 8 specific questions to ask my accountant. Note where the rules vary by country and I need to verify.

TOOLS ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini

055

Negotiate a bill or a price

A script for getting a better deal.

Broadband, insurance, gym memberships, and phone contracts are all routinely negotiable, and most people never try. Tell AI what you're paying, how long you've been a customer, what competitors are charging, and ask for a script - what to say, what to say when they refuse, and when to ask for the retentions department. Ask for the specific phrases that work and the ones that don't. Then rehearse it as a role-play, with the AI playing an unhelpful call-centre agent. Fifteen minutes of preparation for a call that could save a few hundred a year is an unusually good return on effort.

TRY THIS PROMPT

I've been with the same broadband provider for 4 years paying 45 a month. A competitor offers similar speed for 28. Write me a phone script to negotiate a better rate: opening line, what to say when they refuse, when to escalate, and when to actually walk away. Then role-play the call as an unhelpful agent.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

056**Understand your insurance or medical paperwork**

Decode claims, denials, and explanations of benefits.

Medical bills and insurance statements are among the least readable documents most people ever receive. Upload one - redacting names and identifying numbers - and ask what each line means, whether the charges look consistent with the policy, and what your options are if a claim was denied. Ask it to draft an appeal letter citing the specific policy language, which is a task people routinely give up on and which insurers count on them giving up on. This isn't legal or medical advice, but it turns an intimidating document into something you can act on, which is often the difference between appealing and not.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Here's an insurance claim denial letter with personal details removed. Explain in plain English why it was denied, whether that reason is consistent with the policy wording I've also uploaded, and what my options are. If there's a case for appeal, draft the appeal letter citing the specific policy language.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT

057**Plan a big purchase properly**

Requirements first, options second.

The mistake people make with big purchases is starting from products rather than requirements. Describe your situation, budget, and what you need it to do, and ask AI to first define the criteria that matter and rank them - before naming a single product. Then ask for options against those criteria, with a table and honest trade-offs. Ask what the cheapest option that meets your genuine needs is, and separately what you'd regret not spending more on. Use a search-connected tool for current prices and availability. The requirements-first sequence produces noticeably better decisions than browsing reviews.

TRY THIS PROMPT

I need a laptop for photo editing and travel, budget 1,200, and I currently have a 7-year-old machine. Before recommending anything, define and rank the criteria that should matter for my use case. Then compare three current options against those criteria in a table, with honest trade-offs and what I'd regret not spending more on.

TOOLS Perplexity, ChatGPT, Gemini

058

Write the difficult admin letter

Complaints, appeals, cancellations, and formal requests.

Formal letters follow conventions most people don't know: reference numbers at the top, a clear statement of the issue with dates, what you want, and a deadline for response. Describe your situation and ask for a letter in the appropriate register, firm but not aggressive. Ask it to include the specific things that make organisations take a letter seriously - dates, amounts, previous contact reference, and a clear next step if they don't respond. For regulated sectors, ask what the standard complaints escalation route is, then verify it. This is the difference between a complaint that gets processed and one that gets filed.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Write a formal complaint to an airline. My flight was cancelled 3 hours before departure on 14 March, I was rebooked 2 days later, and I paid 180 for a hotel. I've emailed twice with no reply. Firm and professional, not angry. Include what I want, a response deadline, and mention escalation if they don't respond.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

059**Track a goal and stay honest about progress**

A weekly check-in that notices when you're drifting.

Set a goal with the AI, define what weekly progress looks like in measurable terms, then check in every week and report what actually happened. Ask it to compare against the plan, tell you whether you're on track, and - this is the important instruction - to be direct rather than encouraging when you're not. Ask what pattern it notices across several weeks, since that's the thing you can't see from inside. Using a project or saved chat means the history persists so it can genuinely track over time. The mechanism is mundane and it works: regular measurement plus something that remembers what you said last week.

TRY THIS PROMPT

My goal is to write 500 words a day for 90 days. Each Sunday I'll report what I actually did. Compare against the plan, tell me if I'm on track, and be blunt rather than encouraging when I'm not. After four weeks, tell me what pattern you notice in when I skip days.

TOOLS Claude Projects, ChatGPT, Gemini

060**Get help with a decision you keep going in circles on**

Structure a choice you've been avoiding.

For decisions that resist pros-and-cons lists, ask AI to structure the problem instead of answering it. Ask what you're really choosing between underneath the surface question. Ask what a version of you in five years would say. Ask what would have to be true for each option to be obviously right. Ask what you'd advise a friend in the same position, then why you're not taking your own advice. These are reflective prompts rather than analytical ones, and they work because articulating a decision to something that asks reasonable follow-up questions is most of what makes it clearer. Keep the final call yourself.

TRY THIS PROMPT

I've been going back and forth for months about leaving my job to go freelance. Don't tell me what to do. Instead ask me the six questions that would most clarify this decision, one at a time, waiting for my answer each time. At the end, reflect back what my answers suggest I actually want.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

CHAPTER 6

06

Images and Design

You do not need design skills to make good-looking things any more. What you need is taste, patience, and the willingness to try a prompt six times. This chapter covers making images from nothing, fixing the ones you have, and producing the everyday design work that used to require hiring someone.

61 Generate an image from a description

62 Create images with readable text in them

63 Edit a photo by describing the change

64 Cut out a background in two seconds

65 Restore and upscale old or blurry photos

66 Design a logo you can actually use

67 Make social media graphics without a designer

68 Visualise a room before you renovate it

69 Turn a rough sketch into a finished illustration

70 Make diagrams and charts that explain something

71 Generate consistent characters and brand imagery

72 Get a design critique before you publish

061

Generate an image from a description

Type what you want to see and get a picture.

Image generators turn text into pictures. Midjourney produces the most consistently beautiful results, ChatGPT's built-in generator is the easiest for beginners, Google's Imagen inside Gemini is fast and free, and open models like FLUX offer the most control. The difference between a bad result and a good one is almost entirely in the prompt. Describe the subject, then the setting, then the style, then the lighting, then the framing. Vague prompts give generic images. Then iterate - change one thing at a time and regenerate. Expect to try five or six times; that's normal, not failure.

TRY THIS PROMPT

A ceramic coffee cup on a weathered wooden table beside a window, morning light coming from the left, shallow depth of field, warm muted colour palette, shot on 50mm lens, photorealistic, cosy and quiet mood.

TOOLS Midjourney, ChatGPT, Gemini, FLUX, Ideogram

062

Create images with readable text in them

Posters, logos, and graphics where the words come out right.

Rendering text inside a generated image used to be a reliable disaster. It's largely solved now, but not equally across tools - Ideogram was built specifically for text and remains the most dependable, with ChatGPT and Gemini close behind. Put the exact words in quotation marks in your prompt and specify where they should sit and roughly what the typography should feel like. Keep it short: a headline works, a paragraph won't. Always check the spelling in the output, because

mistakes still slip through. This makes quick posters, social graphics, and event flyers achievable in a couple of minutes.

TRY THIS PROMPT

A minimalist event poster with the text "SUMMER SESSIONS" in large bold sans-serif at the top and "Every Friday, 7pm" in smaller text at the bottom. Cream background, single terracotta geometric shape in the centre, generous white space, Swiss design influence.

TOOLS Ideogram, ChatGPT, Gemini, Midjourney

063**Edit a photo by describing the change**

Remove, add, or alter parts of an image with words.

Modern editors let you point at part of a photo and say what you want changed. Remove the stranger in the background, change the sky, take the cable out of the shot, make the room look furnished. Google Photos' Magic Editor, Adobe Photoshop's Generative Fill, and Canva's Magic Studio all do this, and ChatGPT and Gemini can now edit uploaded images conversationally. The results are excellent on simple backgrounds and less reliable on complex ones, hands, and text. Work in small steps rather than asking for five changes at once, and keep the original file.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Remove the parked car and the bin from the left side of this photo, keep everything else exactly as it is, and match the lighting and texture of the surrounding pavement so the edit isn't visible.

TOOLS Google Photos, Photoshop, Canva, ChatGPT, Gemini

064

Cut out a background in two seconds

Clean product shots and profile pictures.

Removing a background used to be twenty minutes of careful selection work. Remove.bg, Canva, Photoroom, and Photoshop now do it in one click, including hair and fur, and it's free at low volumes. This is the workhorse of anyone selling online: a phone photo of a product on a kitchen table becomes a clean catalogue image on white. Photoroom goes further and will place the cut-out object into a generated setting - your candle on a marble surface with soft shadows - which produces genuinely usable product photography without a studio. Check the edges at full zoom before you publish.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Remove the background from this product photo, then place the product on a clean white surface with a soft natural shadow and even studio lighting, suitable for an e-commerce listing.

TOOLS Remove.bg, Photoroom, Canva, Photoshop

065

Restore and upscale old or blurry photos

Rescue family photographs and low-resolution images.

Upscalers add detail to small or soft images, and restoration tools repair scratches, fading, and damage in scanned photographs. Topaz Photo AI is the strongest paid option; Google Photos, Photoroom, and various free web upscalers handle everyday cases. Colourising black-and-white family photos is a popular use and the results can be genuinely moving. One honest caveat: these tools invent plausible detail rather than recovering real detail. A restored face is an educated guess. That's fine for a family album and not fine for anything evidential, journalistic, or legal.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Restore this scanned 1960s family photograph: repair the scratches and creases, reduce the fading, sharpen the faces, and upscale it to print quality. Keep it black and white and don't change anyone's features.

TOOLS Topaz Photo AI, Google Photos, Photoroom

066

Design a logo you can actually use

Brand marks for a small business or side project.

Describe your business, your audience, and the feeling you want, and ask for logo concepts. Then narrow: pick a direction, ask for variations, and refine. Two practical realities. First, generated logos come out as flat images, and a real logo needs to be a vector file that scales - so take the concept you like and have a designer redraw it, or trace it in a vector tool. Second, be careful about accidental similarity to an existing brand; run a trademark search before committing. Used as an idea generator rather than a final deliverable, it works well and costs almost nothing.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Generate 6 logo concepts for a small-batch coffee roaster called Ember. Audience is people who care about origin and craft. Feeling: warm, quiet, a bit rugged, not corporate. Simple enough to work at 32px. Show them on a plain background, no mockups, and explain the thinking behind each.

TOOLS Midjourney, ChatGPT, Ideogram, Canva

067

Make social media graphics without a designer

On-brand posts, stories, and banners at speed.

Canva's Magic Studio is the practical choice for most people: it generates designs from a prompt, resizes one design across every platform's dimensions automatically, and keeps your colours and fonts consistent through Brand Kit. Adobe Express does the same within the Adobe ecosystem. The workflow that saves the most time is making one good design, then using the resize function to produce the twelve variants. Ask for text that fits the space rather than writing it separately, and always preview at actual size on a phone, because what looks fine on a laptop is often unreadable in a feed.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Create an Instagram post announcing a 20% weekend sale for a plant shop. Warm, natural, hand-made feeling - not a loud discount aesthetic. Then resize it for Instagram Story, Facebook post, and a website banner, keeping the design consistent.

TOOLS Canva, Adobe Express

068

Visualise a room before you renovate it

See what a space would look like with changes.

Photograph a room and ask AI to show it with different paint, flooring, furniture, or layout. Interior-specific tools exist, but general image editors in ChatGPT, Gemini, and Photoshop handle this well enough for deciding whether you like an idea. This is genuinely useful before spending money, and it's also good for the conversation with a partner or a contractor - showing is faster than describing. Treat the output as a mood board rather than a plan: proportions will be slightly off, and it won't tell you whether the wall is load-bearing.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Here's a photo of my living room. Show me the same room with the walls painted deep green, the carpet replaced with light oak flooring, and the sofa in a warm cream fabric. Keep the room's proportions, windows, and lighting exactly as they are.

TOOLS ChatGPT, Gemini, Photoshop, Canva

069**Turn a rough sketch into a finished illustration**

Draw badly, get something usable back.

Photograph a pencil sketch, a whiteboard drawing, or a napkin diagram and ask for a polished version in a specified style. This preserves your composition and idea while improving the execution, which is often exactly what you want - you knew what you wanted, you just can't draw it. It works for product concepts, room layouts, character designs, and diagrams. Krea and similar tools do this in real time as you draw. Be specific about style, because "make it better" produces something generic; "flat vector illustration, three colours, thick outlines" produces something you can use.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Here's a rough pencil sketch of a market stall layout. Turn it into a clean flat vector illustration with thick outlines and a three-colour palette of navy, cream and coral. Keep my composition and proportions exactly - just improve the execution.

TOOLS ChatGPT, Krea, Midjourney, Adobe Firefly

070**Make diagrams and charts that explain something**

Visualise a process, structure, or set of numbers.

Describe a process or paste a block of text and ask for a diagram. Napkin turns written text into flowcharts and visuals automatically. Alternatively, ask any assistant to generate the diagram as Mermaid code - a simple text format - which you can then render for free and edit later, and which produces much cleaner results than trying to generate a diagram as an image. For data, upload a spreadsheet and ask for a chart, specifying the point you want it to make. The prompt that improves charts most is naming the takeaway: "make it obvious that growth stalled in Q3."

TRY THIS PROMPT

Turn this description of our customer onboarding process into a clear flowchart. Give it to me as Mermaid code so I can edit it later. Show the decision points and what happens on each branch, and keep it readable on one page.

TOOLS Napkin, ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini

071

Generate consistent characters and brand imagery

The same person or style across many images.

The hard problem in AI imagery is consistency - getting the same character or visual style across a series rather than twelve unrelated pictures. Midjourney has character and style reference features for this, and most tools now accept a reference image. The practical method: create one image you love, then use it as a reference for everything after, and keep a written style prompt you paste every time. This matters for anyone building a brand, illustrating a children's book, or making a comic. Expect it to be imperfect; consistency is much better than it was and still the weakest part of image generation.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Using the attached image as a character reference, generate the same character in three new scenes: reading at a kitchen table, walking a dog in the rain, and asleep on a train. Keep her face, hair, clothing style, and the illustration style identical across all three.

TOOLS Midjourney, ChatGPT, FLUX, Adobe Firefly

072**Get a design critique before you publish**

Feedback on layout, hierarchy, and readability.

Upload a screenshot of your website, poster, slide, or CV and ask for a critique. Ask what a viewer notices first and whether that's the right thing. Ask about visual hierarchy, contrast, spacing, and whether the text is readable at the size it'll actually be seen. Ask what looks amateurish, which is a question people rarely ask and which produces the most useful answers. As with writing, you must explicitly forbid praise or you'll get compliments. This won't replace a designer's eye, but it reliably catches the obvious problems that make work look unfinished.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Here's a screenshot of my homepage. Skip all compliments. Tell me what a first-time visitor notices in the first two seconds and whether that's right, three specific problems with the visual hierarchy, any contrast or readability issues, and the single change that would most improve how professional it looks.

TOOLS ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini

CHAPTER 7

07

Video, Audio and Music

Video and audio production used to require equipment, software, and years of practice. Most of that has collapsed in the last two years. This chapter covers what's now realistically possible for someone with a laptop and no experience - and where the results still give themselves away.

73 Generate a video clip from a text description

74 Edit video by editing the transcript

75 Make a presenter-led video without filming yourself

76 Cut long videos into short clips automatically

77 Add subtitles and translate your video

78 Clean up bad audio

79 Turn text into natural-sounding speech

80 Transcribe any recording accurately

81 Compose original music from a description

82 Separate the parts of a recording

83 Write a video script that holds attention

84 Plan and produce a podcast episode

073**Generate a video clip from a text description**

Type a scene, get moving footage.

Text-to-video is the fastest-moving area in AI. Google's Veo, Runway, Kling, Luma, and Pika all generate short clips - typically five to ten seconds - from a written prompt, and several now generate synchronised audio too. Prompt them like a director: subject, action, camera movement, lens, lighting, mood. Expect to generate many clips to get one good one, and expect physics and hands to occasionally misbehave. It is not yet a replacement for filming something real, but for b-roll, concept work, social clips, and establishing shots it's already good enough to use.

TRY THIS PROMPT

A slow dolly shot moving forward through a misty pine forest at dawn, shafts of low sunlight cutting between the trunks, dust and moisture visible in the air, cinematic, shallow depth of field, calm and unhurried, no people.

TOOLS Veo, Runway, Kling, Luma, Pika

074**Edit video by editing the transcript**

Cut footage by deleting words in a document.

Descript transcribes your video and then lets you edit the footage by editing the text - delete a sentence in the transcript and it disappears from the video. It also removes filler words like "um" and "you know" with one click, which alone saves hours on any talking-head content. For anyone who finds a traditional video timeline intimidating, this is the single biggest unlock in video production. Similar features now exist in Premiere Pro and CapCut. It works best on interviews, tutorials, and podcasts, and less well on anything heavily edited to music.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Transcribe this 40-minute interview, remove all filler words and long pauses, and identify the five most quotable 30-60 second segments with timestamps that would work as standalone clips.

TOOLS Descript, Premiere Pro, CapCut

075**Make a presenter-led video without filming yourself**

An AI avatar delivers your script to camera.

Synthesia and HeyGen turn a written script into a video of a realistic presenter speaking it, in dozens of languages. This is widely used for internal training, product explainers, and localised marketing, where filming and re-filming a real presenter in eight languages is impractical. You can also create an avatar of yourself from a short recording. Quality is good and improving, though most viewers can still tell. The ethical line is firm and worth stating: only ever make an avatar of someone who has explicitly agreed, and label synthetic presenters where a viewer might reasonably assume they're real.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Turn this 400-word script into a presenter video with a professional female avatar in a neutral office setting. Generate it in English, Spanish, and German with the same avatar, and add clean subtitles in each language.

TOOLS Synthesia, HeyGen

076**Cut long videos into short clips automatically**

Find the best moments and format them for social.

Opus Clip, Vizard, and similar tools take a long video - a podcast, webinar, or livestream - and identify the segments most likely to perform as short-form clips, then crop them to vertical, add animated captions, and keep the speaker centred in frame. This is the standard workflow for anyone repurposing long-form content, and it turns a two-hour recording into a month of social posts. The clip selection is decent but not brilliant, so review what it picked. Captions are the important part regardless: most short-form video is watched with the sound off.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Take this 90-minute podcast episode and produce 10 vertical clips of 30-60 seconds each. Pick moments that stand alone without context, add animated captions, keep the speaker centred, and give each clip a suggested title for social.

TOOLS Opus Clip, Vizard, Descript

077

Add subtitles and translate your video

Captions in your language and several others.

Automatic captioning is now genuinely accurate, including in noisy audio and across accents. Most editors - CapCut, Descript, Premiere, YouTube itself - will generate captions in one click and let you style them. Translation goes further: HeyGen and others will dub your video into another language and adjust the lip movement to match. For creators, this multiplies your potential audience at almost no cost. Always read through the generated captions before publishing, because names, technical terms, and numbers are where errors cluster, and a wrong number in a caption is worse than no caption.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Generate accurate subtitles for this video, styled as large white text with a subtle shadow, positioned in the lower third. Then produce translated subtitle files in Spanish, French, and Hindi. Flag any technical terms or proper nouns you were unsure about.

TOOLS CapCut, Descript, HeyGen, YouTube

078**Clean up bad audio**

Remove background noise, echo, and hum.

Adobe Podcast Enhance is free and startlingly effective: upload a recording made on a laptop microphone in a room with an air conditioner, and it comes back sounding close to a studio. Descript's Studio Sound and Auphonic do similar work. For anyone recording interviews, podcasts, lectures, or video from a home office, this is the highest-value free tool in this chapter. It can over-process very poor recordings and give voices a slightly synthetic quality, so listen back before publishing, and keep the original in case you prefer it.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Clean up this recording: remove the background hum and room echo, level the two speakers who are at very different volumes, and reduce the mouth clicks. Keep it sounding natural rather than over-processed.

TOOLS Adobe Podcast, Descript, Auphonic

079**Turn text into natural-sounding speech**

A realistic voice reads your words aloud.

ElevenLabs sets the standard for synthetic voice, and Google, OpenAI, and Microsoft all offer good alternatives. Use it to narrate videos, produce audio versions of articles, create audiobook drafts, or add voiceover to a course. You can clone your own voice from a few minutes of recording, which is useful for correcting a single mis-spoken line without re-recording a whole session. The rule is simple and non-negotiable: clone only your own voice or one you have explicit permission to use. Voice cloning without consent is used for fraud and is illegal in an increasing number of places.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Read this 500-word script in a warm, conversational female voice at a moderate pace, as if explaining something to a friend rather than presenting. Pause naturally at paragraph breaks and don't over-emphasise.

TOOLS ElevenLabs, OpenAI TTS, Google, Speechify

080

Transcribe any recording accurately

Interviews, lectures, and voice notes as searchable text.

Whisper-class transcription is now accurate enough for professional use, handles accents and background noise well, and works across dozens of languages. Otter, Fireflies, Descript, and Notion all offer it; OpenAI's Whisper is free and open if you're comfortable running it yourself. Journalists, researchers, students, and anyone who conducts interviews get the most from this. The real payoff comes afterwards: once the recording is text, you can paste it into an assistant and ask questions of it, pull out themes, or find every mention of a topic across dozens of interviews.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Transcribe this interview with speaker labels and timestamps. Then give me: the three main themes, the five most quotable passages with timestamps, and anything the interviewee seemed reluctant to answer directly.

TOOLS Whisper, Otter.ai, Descript, Fireflies

081

Compose original music from a description

Full songs, or background music for your projects.

Suno and Udio generate complete songs - vocals, instruments, structure - from a text description, and the results are startling the first time you hear them. Describe genre, mood, instrumentation, tempo, and subject, or write your own lyrics and have them performed. The practical use for most people is background music for videos, podcasts, and presentations, where licensing real music is expensive and complicated. Check each service's terms carefully regarding commercial use and ownership, since these vary and are evolving. And be honest with yourself about whether the result is good or just impressive.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Write and produce a 90-second instrumental track: warm acoustic guitar with light percussion and a subtle string pad, mid-tempo, hopeful but understated, suitable as background music for a documentary-style video. No vocals, no big crescendo.

TOOLS Suno, Udio

082

Separate the parts of a recording

Split vocals, drums, and instruments from a mixed track.

Stem separation tools pull a finished recording apart into its component parts - vocals, drums, bass, other instruments - which used to be effectively impossible. Musicians use it for practice and remixing, karaoke enthusiasts for backing tracks, and producers for sampling. LALAL.AI, Moises, and Spleeter all do this well, with free tiers. It's also useful outside music: isolating a voice from a noisy field recording, or removing music from behind dialogue in old video. Copyright still applies to whatever you separate - the tool changes what's technically possible, not what you're allowed to publish.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Separate this track into four stems: vocals, drums, bass, and other instruments. Then give me a version with the vocals removed for use as a backing track, keeping the rest at the original balance.

TOOLS LALAL.AI, Moises, Spleeter

083

Write a video script that holds attention

Structure, hooks, and pacing for video content.

Ask for a script with a specified duration and a structure appropriate to the platform. The crucial instruction is the opening: on short-form video you have about two seconds, so ask for five different hooks and pick the strongest. Ask for the script formatted with visual directions alongside the narration, so you know what to show while each line is spoken. Ask it to mark where the pacing sags. Reading it aloud with a timer is the real test - written text is almost always longer than it sounds, and roughly 140 words per minute is a realistic speaking pace.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Write a 60-second script explaining what a credit score is, for people in their early twenties. Give me 5 different opening hooks first, then the full script in two columns: narration and what to show on screen. Mark where the pacing risks losing someone.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

084**Plan and produce a podcast episode**

From topic to published episode.

Use AI across the whole chain: brainstorm episode topics, research the subject, write an interview guide with questions that go beyond the obvious, transcribe the recording, clean up the audio, generate show notes with timestamps, write the episode description, and cut social clips. Each step saves twenty to forty minutes, and together they remove most of the production burden that stops people publishing consistently. The one thing to keep human is the conversation itself. Ask for questions that a guest hasn't been asked in every other interview - that's where episodes become worth listening to.

TRY THIS PROMPT

I'm interviewing a marine biologist about coral restoration for a general-audience podcast. Give me a 45-minute interview guide: an opening question that isn't boring, 10 substantive questions building in depth, 3 questions she probably hasn't been asked before, and a closing question. Note where I should follow up rather than move on.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Descript, Adobe Podcast

CHAPTER 8

08

Business, Marketing and Side Income

If you run something - a business, a freelance practice, a side project - AI removes most of the work that was previously the reason you couldn't compete with larger operations. The following ten are the ones that most reliably move revenue rather than just saving time.

85 Research a market before you commit to it

86 Write a business plan you'd actually use

87 Build a content calendar and fill it

88 Write product descriptions and sales copy

89 Set up a customer service assistant

90 Personalise outreach at scale without sounding automated

91 Understand what your customers are telling you

92 Improve your search visibility

93 Price what you sell with more confidence

94 Create a lead magnet or digital product

085

Research a market before you commit to it

Understand demand, competitors, and pricing.

Before building anything, use a search-connected AI to map the landscape: who already serves this market, what they charge, what customers complain about in reviews, and what's underserved. Perplexity is good for this because it cites sources you can check. The prompt that produces the most useful answer is asking what people complain about, since unmet complaints are where opportunities live. Follow it with the uncomfortable question: why might this market be bad? Everything you find here needs verifying, but it gets you from nothing to an informed view in an afternoon rather than a fortnight.

TRY THIS PROMPT

I'm considering starting a meal-prep service for shift workers in a mid-sized UK city. Map the market: who already does this, what they charge, what customers complain about in their reviews, and what seems underserved. Then give me the three strongest reasons this might be a bad idea. Cite sources.

TOOLS Perplexity, ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude

086

Write a business plan you'd actually use

Structure your thinking into something coherent.

Describe your idea and ask for a plan covering the standard sections - offer, customer, competition, pricing, costs, marketing, risks - but the value isn't the document. It's the questions it forces you to answer. Ask it to flag every place where you've assumed something without evidence, and to build a simple financial model showing what you'd need to sell to break even. Then ask what would have to be true for this to work, and how you could test the riskiest assumption cheaply this

month. That last question is worth more than the rest of the plan combined.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Here's my business idea in 200 words. Write a lean business plan covering offer, target customer, competition, pricing, costs, and route to market. Flag every assumption I've made without evidence. Then build a simple break-even model, and tell me the cheapest way to test my riskiest assumption within 30 days.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

087**Build a content calendar and fill it**

A month of marketing planned in one sitting.

Tell AI your business, your audience, your platforms, and how often you can realistically post, and ask for a month of content ideas mapped to a calendar - with a mix of formats and a stated purpose for each post. Then generate the drafts in batches. The failure mode to avoid is producing thirty pieces of interchangeable filler; the fix is insisting each post makes a specific, concrete point drawn from your actual experience. Ask it to include posts that answer real customer questions and posts that show your work, which outperform generic advice content almost everywhere.

TRY THIS PROMPT

I run a small accountancy practice for freelancers. Build me a 4-week LinkedIn content calendar posting 3 times a week. Mix formats. Every post must make one specific, concrete point - no generic advice. Include posts that answer real client questions and posts that show how we work. Give me the calendar first, then the drafts.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

088

Write product descriptions and sales copy

Listings and landing pages that describe benefits, not features.

Describe the product, who buys it, and what problem it solves, then ask for copy at a specified length and tone. The instruction that most improves output is asking for benefits rather than features, and asking it to address the specific objection a buyer would have at the moment of purchase. Ask for three variants so you can test. For e-commerce, ask for a short version for listing pages and a longer one for the product page. Always edit: AI copy tends toward enthusiasm and superlatives, and cutting those out usually makes it more convincing rather than less.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Write a product description for a hand-poured soy candle, 40 hours burn time, cedar and bergamot scent, made in small batches. Buyer is someone buying a gift for a friend. Lead with benefit not feature, address the 'is this worth 28?' objection, no hype words. Give me a 40-word listing version and a 150-word product page version.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

089

Set up a customer service assistant

Answer common questions automatically, around the clock.

Tools like Intercom's Fin, Tidio, and Chatbase let you upload your FAQs, help documents, and past support conversations, and produce a chat assistant that answers from your own material. Configured well, this handles a large share of routine questions and hands anything unusual to a person. The important settings are the escalation rules and the instruction to say "I don't know, let me get someone" rather than guessing - a confidently wrong answer about refunds or delivery costs

more than no answer. Test it yourself with awkward questions before letting it near customers.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Using our uploaded help documents, answer customer questions in our brand voice: friendly, direct, no corporate language. If you're not confident the answer is in the documents, say so and offer to connect them with a person. Never guess about refunds, delivery times, or pricing.

TOOLS Intercom Fin, Tidio, Chatbase

090**Personalise outreach at scale without sounding automated**

Sales and partnership emails that reference something real.

Generic outreach gets ignored. Give AI the prospect's website, recent posts, or company news alongside your offer, and ask for a short email that opens with something specific and true about them, then connects it to what you do. Ask for it to be under a hundred words, because long cold emails don't get read. Keep the research genuine - referencing something real is the entire point, and a fabricated compliment is worse than none. Send fewer, better emails rather than more. And check your local rules on unsolicited commercial email before you start.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Here's a prospect's company page and a recent post from their founder, plus a description of what I offer. Write a cold email under 100 words that opens with something specific and genuinely true about them, connects it to a problem I solve, and asks for one small next step. No flattery, no 'I hope this finds you well'.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

091**Understand what your customers are telling you**

Find themes across reviews, surveys, and support tickets.

Export your reviews, survey responses, or support tickets and upload them. Ask for the recurring themes ranked by frequency, the sentiment split, the specific words customers use to describe your product - which is copy you can reuse verbatim - and the complaints that appear rarely but suggest something serious. This is qualitative analysis that would take an analyst days, done in minutes, and it works on a few hundred responses as well as a few thousand. The most valuable question: what are customers asking for that we don't offer? Strip personal details before uploading.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Here are 400 customer reviews with names removed. Identify the recurring themes ranked by how often they appear, split by positive and negative. Quote the exact phrases customers use to describe what they like. Then flag any rare complaint that suggests a serious underlying problem, and tell me what people are asking for that we don't offer.

TOOLS ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini

092

Improve your search visibility

Understand what people search for and write for it.

Ask AI what questions your potential customers are likely typing into a search engine, then have it group those into topics and suggest content for each. Paste an existing page and ask what it's missing compared to what someone searching that term actually wants to know. Ask for title tags and meta descriptions. A newer consideration worth knowing: increasing numbers of people now ask AI assistants rather than search engines, and being clearly and factually described on the open web is how you get mentioned in those answers. Clear, specific, genuinely useful content serves both.

TRY THIS PROMPT

I'm a wedding photographer in Manchester. List the questions couples are actually typing into search when looking for a photographer, grouped into topics. For each group, suggest a page or article and what it must cover to be genuinely more useful than what already ranks. Then write title tags and meta descriptions for the top five.

TOOLS ChatGPT, Perplexity, Gemini, Claude

093**Price what you sell with more confidence**

Work out what to charge and how to justify it.

Describe your offer, costs, market, and competitors, and ask for pricing options with the reasoning behind each - cost-plus, value-based, and tiered - along with what each signals to a buyer. Ask what you'd have to change about the offer to justify a higher price, which is usually more productive than agonising over the number. Then ask for the words to say when a client pushes back, and rehearse it. Underpricing is the most common mistake among freelancers and small businesses, and having something walk you through the logic tends to raise the number.

TRY THIS PROMPT

I'm a freelance copywriter with 3 years' experience, currently charging 400 for a landing page and always booked out. Give me three pricing approaches with reasoning and what each signals to clients. Tell me what I'd need to change about my offer to justify 900. Then write what I say when a client says it's too expensive.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

094**Create a lead magnet or digital product**

Something worth giving away, or selling.

A checklist, template, guide, or short course is how most small businesses collect email addresses, and it's how many people start earning from what they know. Ask AI what problem your audience would pay to solve, then have it draft the thing - a guide, a set of templates, a workbook. You provide the expertise and judgement; it handles structure and drafting. Gamma or Canva will make it look professional. This book is, in a sense, an example of the category. The rule that separates useful from worthless: it has to solve one specific problem completely rather than covering a broad topic shallowly.

TRY THIS PROMPT

My audience is first-time landlords. Suggest five lead magnets they'd genuinely want, ranked by how specific the problem is. Then draft the strongest one in full - it should solve one problem completely rather than covering the topic broadly. Include a structure, the actual content, and a suggested title.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Gamma, Canva

CHAPTER 9

09

Building Things Without Code

The last six are the ones that surprise people most. You can now build working software by describing it - a website, an app, a tool that does a specific job for you. You will not become a software engineer this way, and you don't need to. You need to be able to make the small thing you want to exist.

95 Build a website by describing it
96 Write a small script to do a boring job
97 Learn to code with a tutor beside you

98 Build a small internal tool for your team
99 Create a custom assistant for one specific job
100 Let an AI agent complete a multi-step task for you

095

Build a website by describing it

A working site from a written brief.

Tools like Lovable, v0, Bolt, and Replit generate a working website from a description, show you the result, and let you refine it by asking for changes in plain English. Framer and Wix have AI site builders that produce more conventional editable sites. Start specific: say what the site is for, who visits it, what pages you need, and what you want visitors to do. Then iterate one change at a time. For a portfolio, a small business site, or a landing page to test an idea, this genuinely works, and it takes an evening rather than a month.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Build a one-page site for a dog-walking business in Bristol. Sections: hero with a booking button, three services with prices, about me, testimonials, contact form, service area map. Warm and friendly, mobile-first, fast. Show me the structure before you build it.

TOOLS Lovable, v0, Bolt, Replit, Framer

096

Write a small script to do a boring job

Automate a repetitive computer task without knowing how to program.

Renaming three hundred files, splitting a spreadsheet, converting a folder of images, pulling data from a hundred web pages - these are all a few lines of code, and you can get them by describing the task. Say exactly what you have, what you want, and what operating system you're on, and ask for step-by-step instructions assuming you've never run a script. Two rules that matter: always work on a copy of your files, never on the originals, and never run a script you don't understand that

touches anything important. Ask it to explain what each part does before you run it.

TRY THIS PROMPT

I have a folder of 300 photos named IMG_0001.jpg etc. I want them renamed to the date they were taken plus a sequence number. I'm on Windows and have never run a script. Give me step-by-step instructions from installing anything I need, explain what the script does line by line, and make it work on a copy so I can't destroy the originals.

TOOLS ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini

097**Learn to code with a tutor beside you**

The fastest way in, if you want to actually learn.

AI has changed learning to program more than it has changed programming. You can ask why your code doesn't work and get an explanation rather than a Stack Overflow thread from 2013. Paste an error message and ask what it means. Ask for the same concept explained three ways. The discipline required: ask for explanations and hints rather than finished code, and type it yourself rather than pasting. If you let it write everything, you'll have working programs and no ability, which is fine for a one-off script and a dead end if you want the skill.

TRY THIS PROMPT

I'm learning Python and this function isn't working. Don't fix it for me. Tell me what the error message means in plain English, ask me what I think the line does, and give me a hint about where to look. Only if I'm still stuck after two attempts should you show me the fix.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, GitHub Copilot, Replit

098

Build a small internal tool for your team

A calculator, tracker, or form that does exactly your job.

Every team has a job that a spreadsheet does badly - a quoting calculator, a shift planner, a stock tracker, an intake form with awkward logic. These are small enough to describe and have built. Ask for a single self-contained web page, since that's the easiest thing to host and share. Describe the inputs, the rules, and what the output should look like. Then test it hard with edge cases, including empty fields and unrealistic numbers, before anyone depends on it. Don't put customer or personal data into a tool built this way without someone technical checking it first.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Build me a single-page quoting calculator for a removals company. Inputs: number of rooms, distance in miles, stairs yes/no, packing service yes/no, date. Rules: [describe pricing]. Output: itemised quote with a total. Clean and simple, works on a phone. Then list the edge cases I should test before using it.

TOOLS Claude, ChatGPT, Lovable, Replit

099

Create a custom assistant for one specific job

Set up an AI configured for a task you repeat.

Rather than re-explaining your context every time, save it. ChatGPT's Custom GPTs, Claude's Projects, and Gemini's Gems all let you write instructions and attach documents once, then start every conversation with that context already loaded. Make one for your writing voice, one for your business context, one for a specific client, one for a subject you're studying. This is the single change that most improves day-to-day results for regular users, and almost nobody does it. Write the

instructions as if briefing a new assistant: what you do, how you like things done, and what to never do.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Create instructions for a custom assistant that helps me with marketing for my bakery. It should know: our products, our tone (warm, plain, no hype), our customers, and that we never use exclamation marks or food puns. It should always ask what channel the copy is for before writing. Write the full instruction text.

TOOLS ChatGPT, Claude Projects, Gemini Gems

100**Let an AI agent complete a multi-step task for you**

Hand over a whole job rather than a single question.

The newest capability is agentic work: rather than answering a question, the AI takes a goal and works through the steps - browsing the web, running code, creating files, checking its own output. ChatGPT, Claude, and Gemini all now offer versions of this, and they can genuinely complete research projects, build documents, and analyse data end to end. The way to get good results is to be explicit about the goal, the constraints, and what the finished output should look like. Check the work: an agent that gets step three wrong will confidently build steps four through nine on top of it.

TRY THIS PROMPT

Research the five largest suppliers of recycled packaging in Europe. For each: what they sell, minimum order quantities, rough pricing if published, and who their customers are. Compile it into a comparison table in a spreadsheet, cite every source, and tell me clearly which figures you couldn't verify.

TOOLS ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini

Ten Rules That Improve Every Prompt

The difference between a bad answer and a good one is almost always here

01

Give it a role and an audience

"You are an experienced editor of business books" and "this is for people with no finance background" both change the output substantially. The model adjusts vocabulary, depth, and assumptions to match. It costs you eight words.

02

Say what good looks like

Specify the length, the format, and the tone. "Under 200 words, as five bullets, plain and direct, no jargon" removes almost all the guesswork. Vague requests get vague answers, and then you blame the tool.

03

Give it your raw material

Paste in your notes, your draft, your data, the email thread, the document. AI is far better at shaping something you provide than at inventing something from nothing. Its worst output is always the output it had to invent.

04

Show an example

If you have something in the style you want, paste it and say "match this." One good example is worth several paragraphs of description, and it is the fastest way to get a tone you can't articulate.

05**Ask for options, not an answer**

"Give me three versions with different approaches" is almost always better than asking for one. You will pick a favourite, or take the opening of one and the ending of another, and you will have learned what you actually wanted.

06**Explicitly forbid praise**

AI assistants default to agreeing with you, which makes them useless as critics. "Skip all compliments", "argue against this", and "give me the three strongest objections and don't soften them" are the phrases that fix it.

07**Break big tasks into steps**

Ask for an outline, approve it, then ask for the draft. Ask for the analysis, then the chart. Long single-shot requests drift; staged ones stay on target and let you correct course before the effort is wasted.

08**Tell it to say when it doesn't know**

"If you're not confident, say so" and "tell me which of these figures you couldn't verify" measurably reduce made-up answers. It won't eliminate them, but a model given permission to be uncertain uses it.

09**Keep going**

The first answer is a draft. Say what's wrong with it. "Too formal." "You missed the point of the second paragraph." "Try a completely different angle." Three rounds of this beats one perfect prompt nearly every time.

10**Save what works**

When a prompt produces something good, keep it in a note. Build a small personal library. Better still, put your recurring context into a Custom GPT, a Claude Project, or a Gemini Gem, so you stop re-explaining yourself every morning.

Using AI Sensibly

Six things worth knowing before you rely on any of this

01

Verify anything that matters

AI states wrong things with the same confidence as right things. Names, dates, statistics, legal rules, medical facts, prices, citations, and anything recent are the highest-risk categories. If a mistake would cost you money, health, or credibility, check it at the source.

02

Be careful what you paste in

Assume that anything you type into a consumer AI tool could be reviewed by a human or used to improve the model, unless you have specifically turned that off or you are on a business plan that guarantees otherwise. Never paste passwords, financial account details, medical records, or other people's personal data. Check your employer's policy before putting work material in.

03

It is not a professional

AI is a genuinely good way to understand your situation, learn the vocabulary, and arrive at a doctor, lawyer, or accountant with sharper questions. It is not a substitute for any of them, and it will not tell you when it is out of its depth.

04

Know where the ethical lines are

Do not clone a voice or likeness without explicit permission. Do not present AI-generated content as a real photograph or a real person's words. Do not use it to fabricate reviews, credentials, or evidence. These are not grey areas, and several of them are illegal.

05**Check the rules that apply to you**

Schools, universities, employers, and clients increasingly have explicit AI policies, and journals and competitions have disclosure requirements. Copyright and commercial-use terms differ between image, music, and video tools. Read them once for the tools you actually use.

06**Keep your own judgement in the loop**

The purpose of these tools is to do the parts of your work that do not need you, so that you can spend more of your attention on the parts that do. If you find yourself accepting output you have not read, or making decisions you have not thought about, that is the point at which the tool has stopped helping.

Glossary

The words people use, in plain English

Agent An AI that carries out a multi-step task on your behalf - browsing, running code, creating files - rather than answering a single question.

Chatbot / Assistant The conversational interface you type into. ChatGPT, Claude, and Gemini are assistants built on top of underlying models.

Context window How much text a model can hold in mind at once. Large windows mean you can upload long documents and it will remember all of it within that conversation.

Custom GPT / Project / Gem A saved setup with your own instructions and documents attached, so you don't re-explain your context every time.

Fine-tuning Further training of a model on specific data to specialise it. Mostly a developer concern; you will rarely need it.

Generative AI AI that produces new content - text, images, audio, video, code - rather than only classifying or predicting.

Hallucination When an AI states something false with complete confidence. The most important limitation to understand.

LLM (Large Language Model) The type of model behind text assistants, trained on vast amounts of text to predict and produce language.

Multimodal A model that handles more than one kind of input or output - text plus images, audio, or video.

Open weights A model whose parameters are published, so anyone can run or modify it. Llama, DeepSeek, and Qwen are examples.

Prompt What you type. The instruction, question, and context you give the AI.

Prompt engineering The practice of writing prompts that reliably produce good results. Ninety percent of it is the ten rules in this book.

RAG (Retrieval-Augmented Generation) Giving a model access to specific documents so it answers from them rather than from memory. This is how NotebookLM and most company assistants work.

Token The unit models process text in - roughly three-quarters of a word. Usage limits and API prices are measured in tokens.

Training data The material a model learned from. Its knowledge has a cutoff date, after which it knows nothing unless connected to search.

Vibe coding Building software by describing what you want in plain language and letting AI write the code.

Tool Directory

Everything named in this book, grouped by job

GENERAL ASSISTANTS

ChatGPT The best all-round starting point. Free tier; paid from about \$20/month.

Claude Strongest for writing, long documents, and careful reasoning. Free tier available.

Gemini Free with a Google account; integrated with Gmail, Docs, and Drive.

Microsoft Copilot Built into Windows and Microsoft 365. Best if your work lives in Office.

SEARCH AND RESEARCH

Perplexity Search-first answers with sources. Best for anything current.

NotebookLM Answers only from documents you upload, with citations. Free and excellent for study.

Elicit / Consensus Search and summarise academic literature.

WRITING

Grammarly Continuous grammar and style checking across your browser and apps.

DeepL The best pure translator for long text, especially European languages.

IMAGES AND DESIGN

Midjourney The most consistently beautiful image generation. Paid.

Ideogram Best for images containing readable text - posters, logos.

Canva Design, resizing, background removal, and brand consistency. Generous free tier.

Adobe Firefly / Photoshop Generative editing inside professional tools.

Remove.bg / Photoroom One-click background removal and product photography.

Topaz Photo AI Upscaling and photo restoration. Paid.

VIDEO

Veo / Runway / Kling / Luma / Pika Text-to-video generation. Most have limited free tiers.

Descript Edit video and audio by editing the transcript. Free tier available.

Synthesia / HeyGen AI presenter videos and multi-language dubbing.

Opus Clip Automatically cut long video into short vertical clips.

CapCut Free editor with strong automatic captions.

AUDIO AND MUSIC

ElevenLabs The leading text-to-speech and voice cloning tool.

Adobe Podcast Enhance Free, and remarkably good at cleaning up bad audio.

Suno / Udio Generate complete original songs from a description.

Whisper / Otter.ai / Fireflies Transcription and meeting notes.

WORK AND PRODUCTIVITY

Notion AI Writing, summarising, and search across your workspace.

Gamma Generate designed presentations from text.

Zapier / Make / n8n Connect apps and automate repetitive workflows.

Granola Meeting notes that work without a bot joining the call.

BUILDING THINGS

Lovable / v0 / Bolt Build working websites and apps by describing them.

Replit Write, run, and host code in the browser with AI assistance.

GitHub Copilot / Cursor AI assistance inside a real code editor.

Your First Thirty Days

If you do nothing else in this book, do this

WEEK 1

Get comfortable

- Create a free account on ChatGPT, Claude, or Gemini. Just one.
- Install the phone app and try voice mode - talk to it while walking.
- Do three things from Chapter 1. Meal planning (#1) and the photo identification one (#4) are the easiest wins.
- Deliberately ask a follow-up every time. Never accept the first answer.

WEEK 2

Apply it to your work

- Pick the task you dislike most and find it in Chapter 2 or 4.
- Upload a real document - a report, a contract, a spreadsheet - and ask questions of it (#16, #40, #50).
- Teach it your writing voice (#19) and save the style brief somewhere you can find it.
- Try an AI notetaker on one meeting (#37).

WEEK 3

Make something

- Generate ten images and notice what changes between a bad prompt and a good one (#61).
- Clean up an old recording (#78) or make a graphic (#67).
- Try Perplexity for a real decision you're making (#7 or #57).
- Use NotebookLM on something you actually need to understand (#27).

WEEK 4**Make it stick**

- Set up one Custom GPT, Project, or Gem for a job you do weekly (#99).
- Automate one repetitive task (#44) or write one small script (#96).
- Write down the five prompts that worked best for you this month.
- Pick the single thing from this book that saved you the most time, and make it a habit.

The Complete List of 100

Every entry, with its page number

EVERYDAY LIFE AND HOME

- 1 Plan a week of meals around what's already in your fridge 9
- 2 Get a workout plan built around your real life 9
- 3 Plan a trip with a realistic day-by-day itinerary 10
- 4 Identify a plant, a bug, or a mystery object from a photo 10
- 5 Fix things around the house with a photo and a conversation 11
- 6 Declutter and organise a room, one decision at a time 12
- 7 Get a straight answer instead of ten browser tabs 12
- 8 Turn a rambling voice note into a clean to-do list 13
- 9 Read a label, a menu, or a sign in another language 14
- 10 Settle a decision by having AI argue both sides 14
- 11 Explain a bill, a contract, or an official letter in plain English 15
- 12 Build a routine or habit plan you might actually keep 16

WRITING AND COMMUNICATION

- 13 Write the email you've been avoiding for three days 18
- 14 Fix your grammar and tighten your writing 18
- 15 Adapt one message for five different audiences 19
- 16 Summarise anything long into something you'll actually read 19

- 17 Beat writer's block with a proper outline 20
- 18 Get honest feedback on something you wrote 21
- 19 Teach AI your writing voice so drafts sound like you 21
- 20 Prepare for a difficult conversation by rehearsing it 22
- 21 Write a speech or toast that doesn't sound like a template 23
- 22 Turn one long piece into a dozen short ones 23
- 23 Write a cover letter that's actually about this job 24
- 24 Reply to reviews, complaints, and awkward comments 25

LEARNING AND STUDYING

- 25 Have anything explained at exactly your level 27
- 26 Turn your notes into flashcards automatically 27
- 27 Build a study guide from your own documents 28
- 28 Practise a language by having real conversations 28
- 29 Get unstuck on a maths or science problem without the answer 29
- 30 Build a learning plan for a skill from scratch 30
- 31 Read academic research without a PhD 30
- 32 Turn a document into a podcast you can listen to 31

- 33 Test yourself with an exam you didn't write 32
- 34 Understand a chart, diagram, or table you can't read 32
- 35 Learn from a YouTube video without watching all of it 33
- 36 Give your children a patient homework tutor 34

WORK AND PRODUCTIVITY

- 37 Never take meeting notes again 36
- 38 Clear your inbox faster 36
- 39 Build a spreadsheet formula by describing it 37
- 40 Analyse a spreadsheet without knowing how to analyse spreadsheets 37
- 41 Build a slide deck from a document 38
- 42 Prepare for a meeting in five minutes 39
- 43 Write the job description, then screen against it 39
- 44 Automate the repetitive task you do every week 40
- 45 Get a project plan with realistic timelines 41
- 46 Turn a messy pile of information into a clean table 41
- 47 Write standard operating procedures for your team 42
- 48 Search across everything your company has written 43
- 49 Get a second opinion before you make a decision 43
- 50 Draft, review, and compare contracts 44

MONEY, ADMIN AND DECISIONS

- 51 Understand where your money actually goes 47
- 52 Build a budget that reflects your real life 47

- 53 Compare financial products without the sales pitch 48
- 54 Prepare for tax season without panic 48
- 55 Negotiate a bill or a price 49
- 56 Understand your insurance or medical paperwork 50
- 57 Plan a big purchase properly 50
- 58 Write the difficult admin letter 51
- 59 Track a goal and stay honest about progress 52
- 60 Get help with a decision you keep going in circles on 52

IMAGES AND DESIGN

- 61 Generate an image from a description 55
- 62 Create images with readable text in them 55
- 63 Edit a photo by describing the change 56
- 64 Cut out a background in two seconds 56
- 65 Restore and upscale old or blurry photos 57
- 66 Design a logo you can actually use 58
- 67 Make social media graphics without a designer 58
- 68 Visualise a room before you renovate it 59
- 69 Turn a rough sketch into a finished illustration 60
- 70 Make diagrams and charts that explain something 60
- 71 Generate consistent characters and brand imagery 61
- 72 Get a design critique before you publish 62

VIDEO, AUDIO AND MUSIC

- 73 Generate a video clip from a text description 64

74 Edit video by editing the transcript	64	88 Write product descriptions and sales copy	74
75 Make a presenter-led video without filming yourself	65	89 Set up a customer service assistant	75
76 Cut long videos into short clips automatically	65	90 Personalise outreach at scale without sounding automated	76
77 Add subtitles and translate your video	66	91 Understand what your customers are telling you	76
78 Clean up bad audio	67	92 Improve your search visibility	77
79 Turn text into natural-sounding speech	67	93 Price what you sell with more confidence	78
80 Transcribe any recording accurately	68	94 Create a lead magnet or digital product	78
81 Compose original music from a description	69		
82 Separate the parts of a recording	69	BUILDING THINGS WITHOUT CODE	
83 Write a video script that holds attention	70	95 Build a website by describing it	81
84 Plan and produce a podcast episode	71	96 Write a small script to do a boring job	81
BUSINESS, MARKETING AND SIDE INCOME		97 Learn to code with a tutor beside you	82
85 Research a market before you commit to it	73	98 Build a small internal tool for your team	82
86 Write a business plan you'd actually use	73	99 Create a custom assistant for one specific job	83
87 Build a content calendar and fill it	74	100 Let an AI agent complete a multi-step task for you	84

A Last Word

The hundred things in this book will not all age equally. Some tools named here will be gone in two years, most will have changed names or owners, and several capabilities that feel remarkable today will feel unremarkable by the time you finish reading.

What will not change is the underlying skill, and it is a simple one. Describe what you want clearly. Give it the context it needs. Say what good looks like. Read the answer critically. Ask again.

That skill transfers to whatever comes next, and it is the only thing in this book actually worth memorising.

The people who get the most out of these tools are not the ones who know the most about them. They are the ones who use them for real work, notice what fails, and adjust. You now have a hundred places to start.

Pick one. Do it today.

START WITH ONE.

Most people open an AI tool once, get an underwhelming answer, and never go back. This guide exists to get you past that first hour.

A hundred specific, useful things — each with a prompt you can copy and the tools that do it best.

